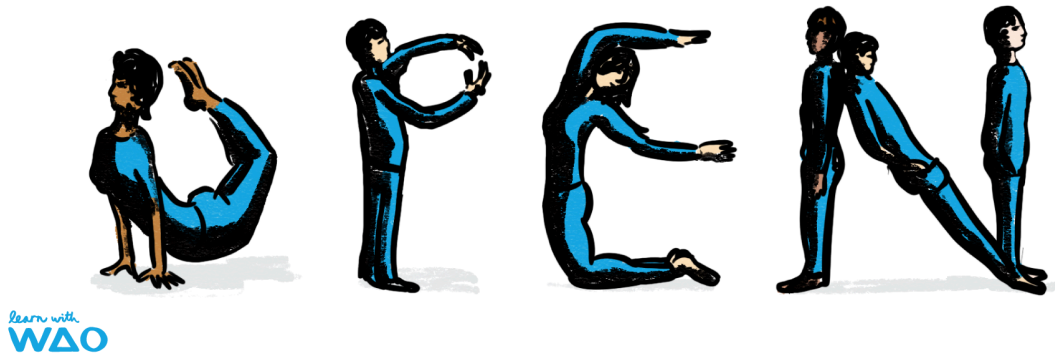


what we talk about WHEN WE TALK ABOUT



Sport England edition

Openness is so much more than just products. It's also about people and processes!

Meta

Five emails, four weeks:

1. Introduction (*week 1, day 1*)
2. Examples (*week 1, day 2*)
3. Behaviours (*week 2*)
4. Tools (*week 3*)
5. Conclusion + next steps (*week 4*)

Threads

- Explicit (specific sections)
 - Greater agility
 - Faster innovation
 - Increased engagement
- Implicit (weaved into text & examples)
 - Inclusivity and diversity

Contents

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[3. Open behaviours](#)

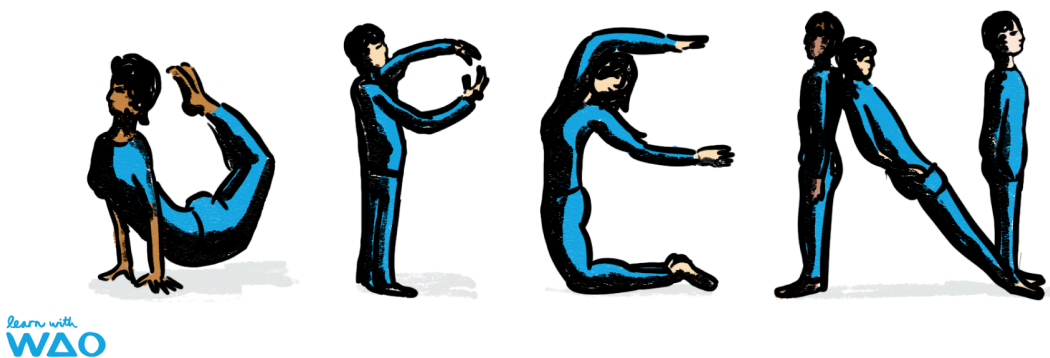
[4. Tools of openness](#)

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1. Introduction

Email subject: 🔒 Introduction: What We Talk About When We Talk About Open

what we talk about
WHEN WE TALK ABOUT



👋 Hello!

Welcome to *What We Talk About When We Talk About Open*, an introductory course from [We Are Open Co-op](#)! We're aiming this at helping organisations affiliated with Sport England harness the three main benefits of open: **greater agility**, **faster innovation**, and **increased engagement**.

These emails are going out every week, meaning the course will cover a four-week period. If someone has forwarded this to you, then consider signing up for yourself [here](#).



OPEN IS AN ATTITUDE

learn with
WAO

But what exactly is openness? After all, we use the word 'open' in different ways - for example, talking of a door or a window being 'open', or having an 'open' position in an organisation.

In fact, there are many, *many* different types of definitions of open, as some academics pointed out a few years ago in a very readable article entitled [Fifty shades of open](#). Here's a few examples they spotted:

- Open means rights
- Open means access
- Open means use
- Open means transparent
- Open means participatory
- Open means enabling openness
- Open means philosophically aligned with open principles

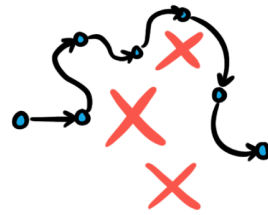
Open is a contested, multifaceted, fluid term. Everyone wants to be seen as 'open' rather than 'closed', so there are vested interests when defining the term. For the avoidance of doubt, we're going to use [The Open Organization Definition](#), which outlines five key characteristics of an 'open' organisation or project:



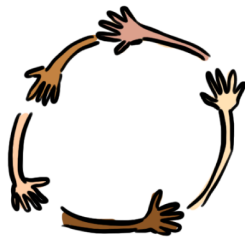
TRANSPARENCY



INCLUSIVITY



ADAPTABILITY



COLLABORATION



COMMUNITY

In this email-based course we'll be sharing tactics to help your organisation learn and embody these characteristics. You should be aware that this is very much an *introductory* course, so we'll signpost you to places where you can find out more when you're ready to take your open journey further!

At the bottom of each email we're going to give you some tasks to complete which, we hope, will help deepen your understanding and knowledge of openness and why it's so valuable. The first one is below, so take a look!

OK, let's start things off on a practical note. So that we've got a baseline, let's consider where your organisation stands *right now*. Be honest!

Here's what to do:

1. [Click here](#)
2. Complete the short survey
3. You will receive a copy of your results by email

If you are taking this email course with others in your organisation (*what a great idea!*), then ask them to share their results too.

Completing this activity in a collaborative way allows you to compare and contrast with your colleagues where you think your organisation currently stands. That could lead to a conversation based on the following:

- How open is your organisation?
- Were you surprised by the results?
- Which of the five principles needs most work in your organisation?

Remember, openness is not like a lightswitch, it's a *continuum*, not a binary. It's also rather contagious – openness begets openness! 😊

Note: if you want to dive more into the socio-economic diversity of your organisation, then the [Social Mobility Commission's cross-industry toolkit](#) may be useful to you. This gives practical advice on how to collect data to inform and improve socio-economic diversity and inclusion.

Next up: we'll be looking at examples of openness in practice, from NGOs to companies such as Google!



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2. Examples

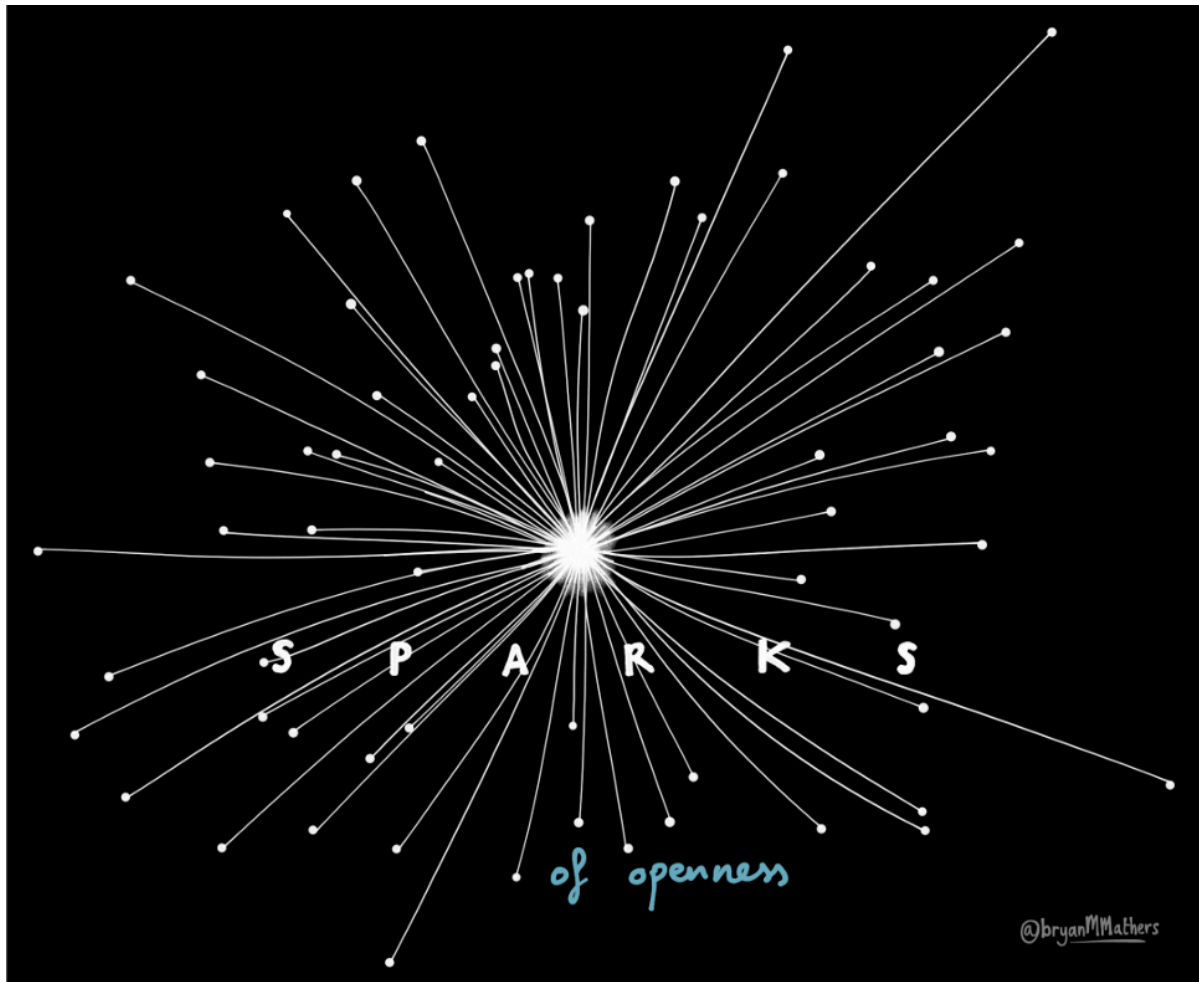
Email subject: 🔒 Examples of openness in practice

👋 Hello again!

Welcome back to *What We Talk About When We Talk About Open*, an email course helping organisations affiliated with Sport England harness the three main benefits of open: **greater**

agility, faster innovation, and increased engagement. If you've had this email forwarded to you from a friend or colleague, you can sign up for yourself [here](#).

Last time, we looked at some definitions of openness and asked you to rate your organisation using the [Open Organisation Maturity Model](#). We'd encourage you to go back and do that, if you haven't already.



One of the barriers to working different to 'business as usual' can be that people want *proof* that a new approach can work. So while we could try and convince you philosophically that openness is the best way forward for you and your organisation, some case studies and examples might serve us better. We are including one example from each (broad) sector, but trust us, there are *a lot more*.

Councils

First off, let's consider councils, which exist to represent the interests of the citizens they serve. What a great reason to be open! After all, we all want our representatives to reap the rewards of the three main benefits of openness: **greater agility, faster innovation, and increased engagement.**



Who? LocalGov Drupal

What problem were they trying to solve? How to improve service delivery, reduce risk and save money for local councils in the UK.

How did they solve it? Collaborating to create a publicly owned asset that delivers a better digital experience for citizens, improves service outcomes, and saves money.

“LocalGov Drupal is what proper local gov digital collaboration looks like. A single platform where everyone gets the benefits of each other's investment for free. Solving problems once, together. I'd urge any council to get on board, it's a no brainer!” (Neil Williams, Chief Digital Officer at Croydon Council, former head of GOV.UK)

Learn more about how [Local Gov Drupal](#) supports local councils in the UK.

NGOs

Next, let's turn to non-governmental organisations, or NGOs as they're known. This type of organisation needs to be able to raise money, working effectively and efficiently so that they can have an impact in line with their mission. Again, they can benefit from the **greater agility, faster innovation, and increased engagement** that working openly offers! Let's look at a couple of examples...



Who? Greenpeace International

What problem were they trying to solve? Trying to streamline technology choices for Greenpeace around the world and find ways to support collaboration at a global scale.

How did they solve it? The Greenpeace Planet 4 team has been implementing an open culture. They are using open principles to develop open software to power Greenpeace websites, via open collaboration techniques, and open engagement.

“Open organizations (or networks of organizations such as Greenpeace) explicitly invite participation from external communities, because these networks know their products and programs are world class only if they include a variety of perspectives at all phases of development.” (Laura Hilliger)

Learn more about opening up organisations with the [Open Organization community books](#).

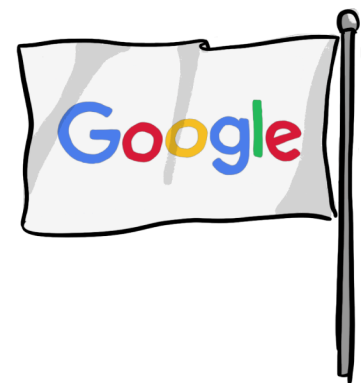
Companies

Finally, let's look at for-profit companies who, of course, absolutely want to ensure that they exhibit **greater agility**, **faster innovation**, and **increased engagement**! That's why so many are finding that working openly is a competitive advantage. We could name many other examples here, such as IBM and Microsoft, but let's focus on a name that everyone knows...

Who? Google

What problem were they trying to solve? How to empower high-performance teams and increase productivity.

How did they solve it? [SCARF](#). Wanting to know what interventions led to high-performing teams, [research from Project Aristotle](#) highlighted the importance of collaboration and employee psychological safety. As a result, Google uses the acronym SCARF, which stands for: Status; Certainty; Autonomy; Relationships; Fairness, to promote inclusion and trust when collaborating openly, so people can contribute their best work.



“Psychological safety is like oxygen. It's the oxygen our brains crave to be honest, creative and curious in front of others. It's what determines whether we feel able to ask a “dumb” question, take a risk, challenge the status quo, or share a crazy idea. In short: it's what allows us to bring our whole brains to work.” (Matt Thompson)

Now that you've got some examples to give you a better flavour of openness in different types of organisations, let's think about how we can *apply* what we've learned this time around.

Here's what to do:

1. Decide which example(s) resonate best with your organisation. Think about what that example of openness would look like if translated to your organisation: would it be exactly the same? Is your context slightly different meaning it would have to be 'translated' in some ways?

2. Reflect on your thinking openly, you're invited to add a post to [the CAST Medium publication](#), or you might write within your organisation in a channel that all (or many) can access. What do *other* people think?

If you need a link to reference this particular part of the course, then you can click [here](#).

Next up: we'll be looking at open behaviours which will involve us checking out everything from open licensing to leading open innovation by example!

Do you want to have a chat about how some of these examples might be tailored for your organisation? [Get in touch](#) to see how we can help!



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3. Open behaviours

Email subject:  Open behaviours

 Hello!

We're bringing you another instalment of *What We Talk About When We Talk About Open* which is aimed at helping you understand and implement open practices. So far we've covered what openness means and some examples of open practices.

Has this email been forwarded to you by a friend or colleague? You can sign up for yourself [here](#)!



One of the advantages of working openly is that you become what we call “comfortable in chaos”. Not that we want *full* chaos to be unleashed, of course, but openness can be, well... delightfully unpredictable sometimes. That’s because to work openly is a very *human* approach.

Before we dig into that further, let’s remind ourselves of those three benefits of open:

- **Greater agility** — members are more capable of working toward goals in unison and with shared vision;
- **Faster innovation** — ideas from both inside and outside the organisation receive more equitable consideration and rapid experimentation, and;
- **Increased engagement** — members clearly see connections between their particular activities and an organisation's overarching values, mission, and spirit.

So why isn’t everyone working openly? After all, who *doesn’t* want all that agility, innovation and engagement!? Everyone **says** they want those things for their businesses, organisations and teams, but we’re going to let you in on a few things that might help...

Open behaviours are inclusive

You can't see, feel, or touch openness. It's like the wind: you can only see its impact and effects. We know we've been open when diverse groups of people feel welcome and included in the work you're doing.

There is a whole world of research and information out there about this, but we should probably touch on **unconscious bias**. This is a brain mechanism that simplifies information so you can use past experiences and knowledge to make decisions or take action more quickly.

This is not always a bad thing. For example, if you've been burned by fire before, you know to be careful around it. However, we often make judgments that are *not related* to the current person, situation or thing. Being aware of unconscious bias is key to understanding why and how we react and perceive our surroundings.

This awareness helps you be inclusive, it's as simple as that. Knowing your tendencies and behaviours and understanding them can help you build empathy. The way we act in shared spaces changes the fabric of those spaces. The way we interact and share changes the way others interact and share with us.

Openness improves **human connection**. It gives us agency, which in turn helps with our physical and mental wellbeing. Then, to close the loop of this virtuous circle, our wellbeing has a positive effect on our efficiency and productivity at work!

Note: if you're confused by terminology around Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DE&I) then [this guide from Babbel](#) is an excellent resource giving an easy-to-read overview.



Open behaviours lead to 'self-organising ducks'

Displaying open behaviours is about generating **trust through transparency**. This trust takes two forms:

- Beginning by trusting others
- Be trustworthy

It's possible to weigh people down with organisational policies and procedures, getting people to 'jump through hoops' which stand between them and the important work they need to be getting on with doing.

Instead, working openly involves trusting people you're working with and being reliable yourself. For example, by ensuring that you don't commit to things that can't be achieved in a given time period, and show up (and on time!) for colleagues.

Fundamentally, open behaviours are about putting your ego to one side. Instead of having your 'ducks in a row', the idea is to instead encourage "self-organising ducks". This involves giving people enough autonomy, trust, and latitude to manage themselves.



Open behaviours encourage remixing

You may have noticed at the bottom of each of our emails that we use **open licensing** on everything we produce. Open licensing allows you to share your work and use that of others without having to be concerned about legal issues.

While there are *many* different licences for all kinds of things from art to computer code, we often fall back on [Creative Commons licenses](#). Openly licensed materials means you don't have to keep reinventing the wheel every time you have a new idea, project or assignment.

Reusing and remixing the ideas of others is [how good ideas come about](#). It's how we make the world a better place. So if you've never looked into it, check out the activity below to learn more about open licensing.

Let's practice some open behaviours through a simple but fun project that you can share with your colleagues and social networks. The point is not just to share, but to reflect on what happens when you do.

Here's what to do:

1. Make your own stamp with [Nice to CC you](#). Just do something fun and creative or make a stamp relevant to Sport England!
2. Share your card with your colleagues, friends and/or on social media. If you use Twitter, tag us @WeAreOpenCoop and @TechForGoodCAST– we'd LOVE to see what you made!
3. Ask for feedback and see what people say. Do others reciprocate?

Next up: we'll be looking at tools and processes for working openly, making a distinction between open source software and open culture, and talking about working 'open by default'.

We Are Open runs in-depth courses on openness that you, your team, and your organisation can access. [Get in touch](#) to find out more!



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4. Tools of openness

Email subject:  Tools of openness

 Hello again!

In this course so far we've covered from definitions of 'open', examples of open working in practice and behaviours that help with openness. The aim is to help you level up your open game, be more inclusive and get ready to be a changemaker in *your* organisation.

If this email has been forwarded to you by a friend or colleague then we really would recommend you signing up for yourself [here](#) to get the full experience!

Benefits of Open

learn with
WAO



greater
AGILITY



faster
INNOVATION



increased
ENGAGEMENT

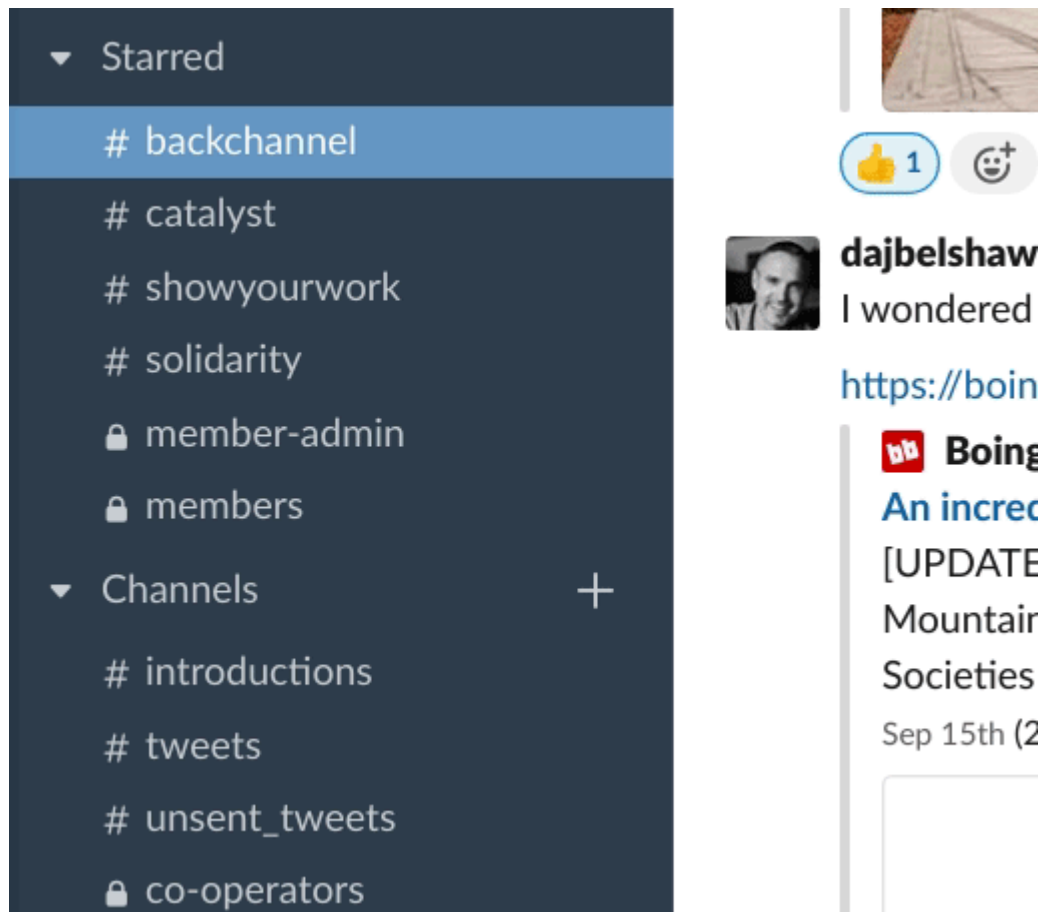
When working openly, even people who are motivated to work with one another need organising and to follow processes. So here are some tools and techniques that might help you and your organisation bring more diverse voices to what you're doing.

Greater agility

Members are more capable of working toward goals in unison and with shared vision

Like many organisations, We Are Open uses a 'workplace chat' platform rather than spending our days emailing one another. In our case, it's [Slack](#), but there are many other, possibly, better options!

Even with a small co-op, when everyone's busy, chatting, and working openly it can get, well, **noisy**. In some organisations that means people retreating to private channels to control this, but we try to keep everything open. After all, as media theorist Clay Shirky famously said, *"it's not information overload, it's filter failure"*.



Platforms like Slack have features that allow you to control, among other things:

- **Who** gets notified about an update
- **When** you can be disturbed by notifications
- **Where** people get updates (i.e. from which channels)

Just as we shouldn't assume people know how to use email well, we shouldn't automatically assume that everyone knows how to use workplace chat apps effectively. So instead of colleagues scurrying off to private channels to avoid notification overload, perhaps have a conversation about organisational use of these kinds of apps?

Top tips

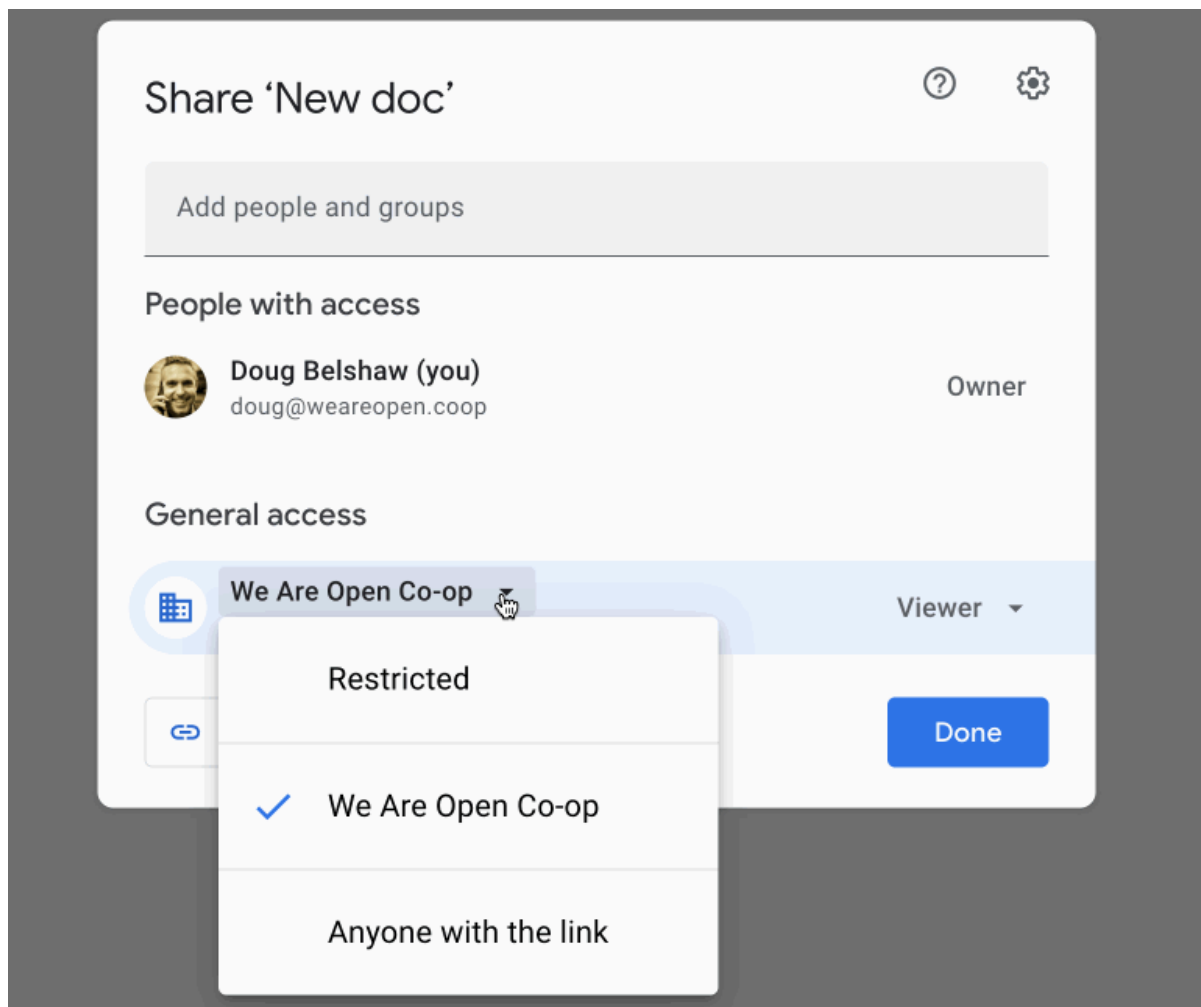
- **Start with small adjustments in your information flow** - for example, make sure each team has their own chat channel, and add complexity when it's necessary.

- **Create spaces specifically for solidarity** - giving marginalised people a place to gather that is just for them can help people feel seen and heard by the organisation.
- **Have regular conversations about your tooling and processes** - the best people to give organisational feedback on tools and processes are those who use them every day. You can keep track of your processes to help new starters and to solve any disputes, which is why we love [our wiki](#).

Faster innovation

Ideas from both inside and outside the organisation receive more equitable consideration and rapid experimentation

One easy way into thinking about the tools we use to work openly is by thinking about the options that Google gives for sharing Docs or YouTube videos. You may be familiar with something like this:



It's tempting to think of these as 'openness' settings, but in actual fact they give only quite simple controls over who can access documents, videos, etc. Our co-op encourages organisations to make work available to the *widest* number of people possible, and then

restrict it as necessary (for example, when dealing with personal data). It's been claimed that knowledge workers sometimes spend up to 40% of their week just trying to *find* the information they need to do their job.

Just to clarify, working openly doesn't **necessarily** mean working *publicly*. Remember, open is not a binary, it's a continuum. You can work openly within your organisation so long as everyone has access to the relevant information.

Top tips

- **Ensure that people have access** - this is the first step to making sure that people can jumpstart innovation. Afterall, if they have access, they can gain context.
- **Schedule regular check-ins and context-setting chats** - structured meetings that reference new and existing documents will help keep you and your colleagues on the same page.
- **Reach out to people for feedback** - if people have access, they can easily comment and add their ideas! Specifically ask for diverse voices to contribute and go the extra mile to make sure those voices feel invited.

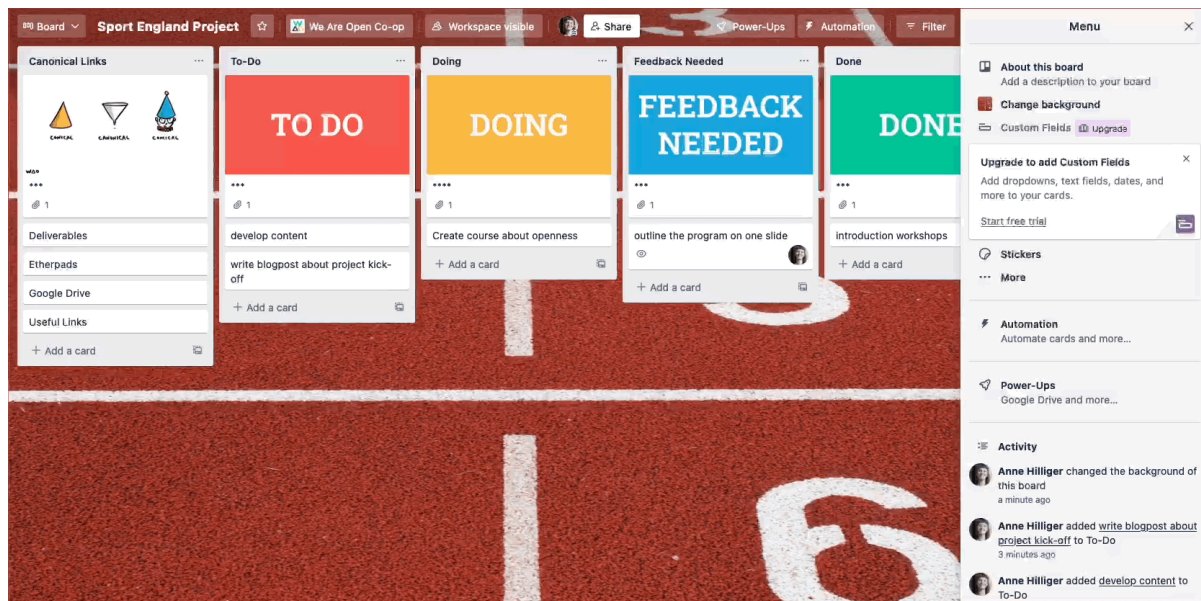
Want to go further? Check out this [Inclusive Design Reading and Resource List](#)

Increased engagement

Members clearly see connections between their particular activities and an organisation's overarching values, mission, and spirit

Working openly is more than theoretically giving people access to something. It's about the process of sharing and **notifying** them. Tools that are good for working openly are therefore those where everyone who *should* be able to see what's going on *can* see what is going on, and can be notified about any updates/changes.

Let's use a concrete example using one of our co-op's favourite tools: [Trello](#). Now you might prefer a different kanban-style tool for tracking what is 'To Do', 'Doing', and 'Done' but for the sake of argument let's use this one. Notice what happens in the **Activity** section on the right-hand side when I move a card from 'To Do' to 'Doing':



Top tips

- **Repetition and structure is useful** - it can be helpful for both engagement and efficiency.
- **Minimise cognitive load** - although not every project is the same, find ways to use templates and formatting so that colleagues can easily duplicate, copy and paste.
- **Be descriptive** - people may not have all the context you or your immediate team have. Provide a bit more structure and context so that people can contribute meaningfully.

Let's practice some open behaviours by changing the way we use tools in open ways.

Here's some practical suggestions:

1. **Control** your notification settings of your workplace chat app so that you can safely ignore things that don't immediately concern you and focus on those things where you can help.
 2. **Share** documents in the most open way possible — that might mean publicly on the web, or it might mean so that everyone in your organisation can see.
 3. **Organise** your work using a platform or tool where others can see what you're up to — not so they can *track* you, but so they can help/advise in timely ways!
 4. **Communicate** with your peers and talk about the processes and structures you're using to work together.
 5. **Ask** people who haven't contributed their ideas how you can make it easier for them to do so.
-

Next up: we'll be looking at the things we have learned in this course, ask for your feedback and say goodbye. .

We Are Open can advise you on specific tools and processes for your organisation. [Get in touch](#) to find out how we can help!

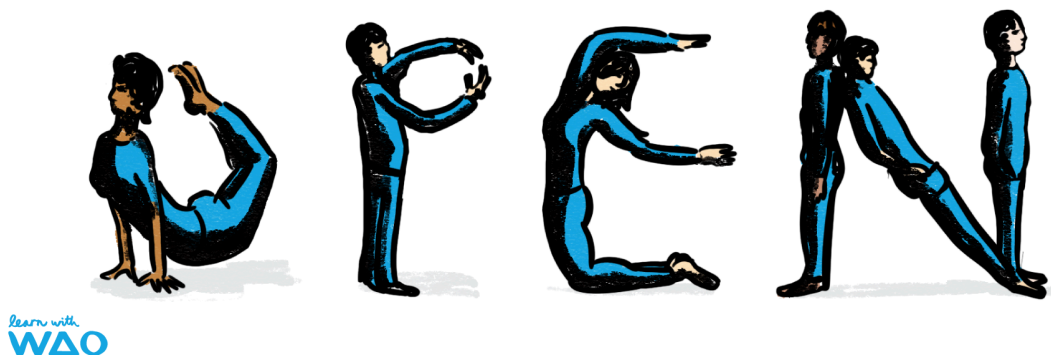


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5. Conclusion

Email subject: 🔒 Conclusion: bringing it all together (and next steps...)

what we talk about
WHEN WE TALK ABOUT



👋 Hello!

Thanks for joining us for this module! We've covered a **bunch** of things over the last couple of weeks, so you might want to revisit previous emails to recap just *some* of the following:

- The benefits of working openly
- Creative Commons licences
- Examples of open working
- What open behaviours look like
- Ways to use tools in more open ways

We can only make this course better based on what you tell us, so would you consider spending five minutes giving us some brief feedback? Thanks in advance!

How likely is it that you would recommend this course to a friend or colleague?

0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

Not at all likely

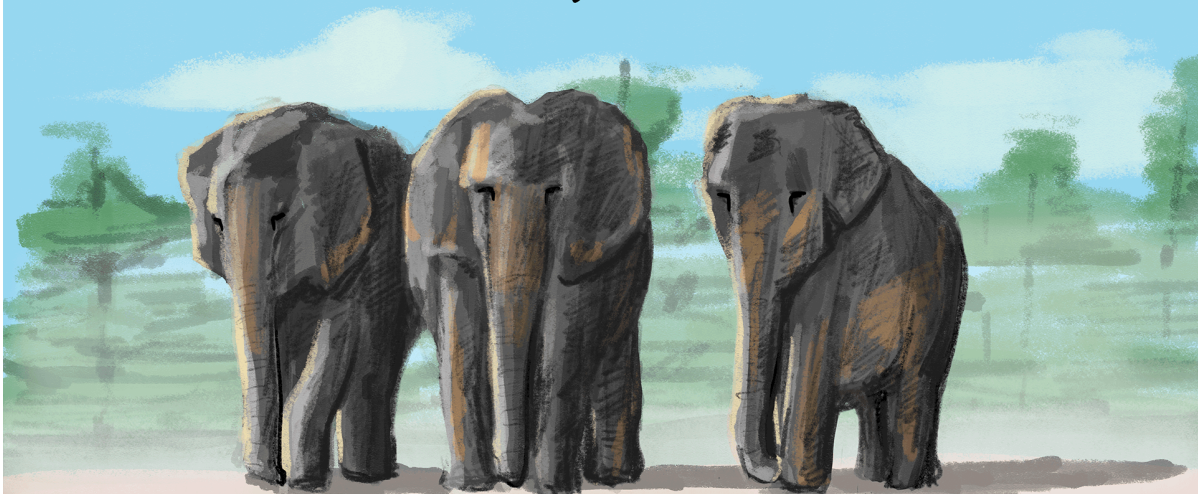
☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

Extremely likely

Next up as part of this programme will be a series of hybrid modules which involve a combination of synchronous and asynchronous elements. Keep your eyes peeled for those from September onwards!

Finally, could you share this course with others who might benefit from it? Just send them to the following link for them to be able to sign up for themselves: XXXXX

IF YOU WANT TO FAST, GO ALONE.



IF YOU WANT TO GO FAR, GO TOGETHER.

WAO

